

# Dill Grow Guide

For dill seedlings, container herbs, kitchen gardens, and small farm herb production.

Quick Rescue - Quick Numbers - Sunlight/Soil/Water - Feeding - Harvesting - Problems - Transplanting

|                |                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Crop           | Dill / Anethum graveolens                                                                                                        |
| Main harvests  | Fresh dill leaves (dill weed), flower heads for pickling, and mature seeds.                                                      |
| Important note | Dill has a taproot and does not like rough transplanting. If bought as a seedling, plant it young and keep the root ball intact. |

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

# 1. Quick Rescue Page: If You See This, Do This

| What You See                        | Most Likely Cause                                   | What To Do First                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Seedling droops after planting      | Transplant shock, root disturbance, sun stress      | Shade 1-2 days, water gently, do not fertilize heavily. Keep the root ball moist, not soggy. |
| Plant falls over or stem base rots  | Damping off or stem/root rot                        | Remove collapsed plants. Improve drainage and airflow. Avoid overwatering.                   |
| Leaves yellowing from bottom        | Too much water, low nitrogen, old leaves            | Check drainage first. If soil is not soggy, feed lightly. Remove yellow leaves.              |
| Leaves look dry, thin, or crispy    | Underwatering / heat stress                         | Water at soil level. Add light mulch. Give afternoon shade during very hot weather.          |
| Plant gets tall and flowers quickly | Bolting from heat, stress, age, or root disturbance | Harvest leaves now. Cut flower stalks if you want leaves; leave flowers if you want seed.    |
| Feathery leaves are chewed          | Caterpillars / parsleyworms / armyworms             | Check early morning and evening. Handpick worms. Use netting if needed.                      |
| Tiny insects on new growth          | Aphids or thrips                                    | Spray with water first. Use mild soap spray every 3-5 days if needed.                        |
| White trails inside leaves          | Leafminers                                          | Remove affected leaves. Keep weeds down. Use insect netting for new plantings.               |
| White powder on leaves              | Powdery mildew                                      | Improve spacing and airflow. Remove badly affected leaves. Avoid wetting foliage late.       |

**For any serious problem, send photos of the full plant, leaf close-up, stem base, soil/pot, and any insects to WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415.**

## 2. Quick Numbers Page

| Item                                         | Specific Range / Target                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Botanical name                               | Anethum graveolens                                                                 |
| Crop type                                    | Fast-growing annual herb                                                           |
| Seed germination                             | 7-21 days                                                                          |
| First leaf harvest from seed                 | 6-8 weeks after sowing                                                             |
| Seedling transplant age                      | 2-4 weeks old; transplant young before roots circle the pot/cell                   |
| Hardening-off period                         | 5-7 days before full outdoor planting                                              |
| Plant height                                 | About 60-150 cm / 2-5 ft, depending on variety and conditions                      |
| Plant spacing for leaves                     | 8-12 inches apart                                                                  |
| Plant spacing for seed heads / larger plants | 12-18 inches apart                                                                 |
| Row spacing for small farmers                | 12-24 inches for hand harvest and airflow                                          |
| Container depth                              | 10-12 inches minimum; deeper is better because dill has a taproot                  |
| Sunlight                                     | 6+ hours daily; in hot lowland areas, morning sun plus light afternoon shade helps |
| Heat stress note                             | Very hot conditions near 35°C / 95°F can reduce seed production and push stress    |
| Soil pH                                      | 5.5-7.5; best around 6.0-7.0                                                       |
| Harvest frequency for leaves                 | Every 7-14 days once strong growth begins                                          |

**Dill is usually easiest from direct seed, but seedlings can work if transplanted gently while young. The main rule is: do not break the taproot or crumble the root ball.**

### 3. Sunlight, Soil, and Water

| Need          | Target / Customer Instruction                                                                                                  |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sunlight      | Give 6+ hours of light daily. In hot Jamaican conditions, morning sun with light afternoon shade is safer for young seedlings. |
| Best location | Open, bright location with airflow. Avoid crowded, damp corners.                                                               |
| Soil          | Loose, well-draining soil with compost. Dill dislikes heavy wet soil.                                                          |
| Soil pH       | 5.5-7.5; aim for 6.0-7.0 when possible.                                                                                        |
| Watering      | Keep evenly moist during establishment. After that, water when the top 1 inch of soil begins to dry.                           |
| Drainage      | Do not let pots sit in standing water. Raise containers if the ground is waterlogged.                                          |
| Mulch         | Use a light mulch to reduce heat and splashing. Keep mulch slightly away from the stem.                                        |

Dill bolts faster when stressed. Consistent water, enough space, and gentle handling help keep leaves coming longer.

### 4. Feeding Guide

| Stage                | Timing                    | Feeding Direction                                                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| At planting          | Day 0                     | Mix compost into the soil. Avoid fresh manure or strong fertilizer touching the roots. |
| After settling       | 7-10 days after planting  | If leaves are pale, give a light liquid feed or mild balanced fertilizer.              |
| Leaf production      | Every 3-4 weeks if needed | Feed lightly only. Too much nitrogen can make weak, soft growth.                       |
| Before heavy harvest | 2-3 days before cutting   | Water evenly. Avoid heavy fertilizer right before harvest.                             |
| Seed production      | When flowers form         | Do not overfeed. Keep plants watered so seed heads fill properly.                      |

**Dill is not a heavy-feeding herb. Rich composted soil and light feeding are usually enough for home gardens and small herb beds.**

## 5. Harvesting Guide

| Harvest Type              | When / How                                                                               |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| First light leaf harvest  | Start when plants are about 6-8 inches tall and have enough leaves to keep growing.      |
| Regular leaf harvest      | Cut outer stems or tips every 7-14 days. Do not strip the whole plant at once.           |
| Best time of day          | Harvest early morning after leaves dry, or late evening after heat drops.                |
| How much to remove        | Remove no more than about 1/3 of the plant at one cutting if you want regrowth.          |
| Flower heads for pickling | Harvest when flower umbrellas open and are still green/yellow, before seeds fully brown. |
| Seed harvest              | Allow seed heads to turn brown. Cut stems and dry upside down in a paper bag.            |
| Fresh handling            | Keep harvested dill shaded and cool. Do not leave bunches in direct sun.                 |

**If the customer wants mostly leaves, cut flower stalks as soon as they appear. If the customer wants seed, leave several strong plants to flower.**

## 6. Leaf Color and Growth Problem Guide

| Leaf / Growth Sign              | Likely Cause                             | What To Do                                                                      |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fresh green, feathery leaves    | Healthy growth                           | Continue steady watering and light harvesting.                                  |
| Pale green leaves               | Low nutrition, low light, or root stress | Improve light. Feed lightly only after checking drainage.                       |
| Yellow lower leaves             | Age, wet soil, or low nitrogen           | Remove yellow leaves. Reduce watering if soil is wet.                           |
| Brown crispy tips               | Heat stress, dry soil, fertilizer burn   | Water evenly. Use light shade in hot afternoons. Avoid strong fertilizer.       |
| Long weak stems                 | Too little light or overcrowding         | Give brighter light and thin/space plants.                                      |
| Plant flowers early while small | Bolting from stress or root restriction  | Harvest leaves now. For future plants, transplant younger and give deeper soil. |

## 7. Bolting and Flower Stalks

Bolting means the plant is moving from leaf production into flowering and seed production. Dill naturally flowers, but heat, root disturbance, crowding, and dry soil can make it happen too early.

| What You See                   | Meaning                      | What To Do                                                                           |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tall center stem rising        | Plant is preparing to flower | Harvest leaves now if you want dill weed.                                            |
| Yellow umbrella flower head    | Normal flowering stage       | Leave it for seed/pickling flowers or cut it to slow seed production.                |
| Small plant flowers very early | Stress bolting               | Check heat, water, root crowding, and transplant shock. Start a new batch if needed. |
| Leaves reduced after flowering | Plant energy shifted to seed | Harvest seeds later or replant fresh dill for leaves.                                |

## 8. Small Farmer Notes

| Topic            | Recommendation                                                                             |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Planting batches | For steady leaf supply, plant or transplant in small batches every 2-3 weeks.              |
| Spacing          | Use 8-12 inches for leaf production; use 12-18 inches if allowing large plants/seed heads. |
| Rows             | Use 12-24 inch row spacing depending on how you weed and harvest.                          |
| Shade strategy   | Use afternoon shade or shade cloth during very hot periods to reduce stress bolting.       |
| Harvest handling | Cut in the cool of the day. Keep bunches shaded and away from hot vehicle interiors.       |
| Market quality   | Remove yellow, dry, insect-damaged, or dirty stems before bunching.                        |

## 9. Home Garden Notes

| Situation            | Recommendation                                                            |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2-6 plants           | Plant 8-12 inches apart in a bright bed or container.                     |
| Container growing    | Use a pot at least 10-12 inches deep with drainage holes.                 |
| Kitchen use          | Harvest small amounts often instead of cutting the whole plant.           |
| Hot patio            | Give morning sun and shade after midday. Check water daily.               |
| Want more dill later | Let one plant flower and drop seed, or plant a new batch every 2-3 weeks. |

## 10. Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

| Practice                                      | Why It Matters                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Wash hands before handling seedlings          | Reduces transfer of pests, disease organisms, and dirty residues.                    |
| Clean scissors/knife before harvest           | Reduces disease spread between plants and keeps herbs cleaner for customers.         |
| Do not handle sick plants then healthy plants | Many plant problems move by hands, tools, splashing water, and insects.              |
| Keep trays off dirty ground                   | Reduces soil splash, ants, slugs, and root disease risk.                             |
| Avoid smoking over seedling trays             | Smoke, ash, and dirty hands are not good handling practice for customer food plants. |
| Remove heavily diseased plants                | Protects the rest of the crop and reduces pest/disease buildup.                      |

**For food herbs, clean handling matters. Customers may eat dill fresh, so use clean water, clean containers, and clean tools.**

## 11. Hardening Off Seedlings

Hardening off prepares seedlings for direct sun, wind, and outdoor heat. Dill should be hardened off gently because stress can trigger early flowering.

| Day     | Exposure                                                                   |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 1-2 | Bright shade for 2-3 hours, then back to protected area.                   |
| Day 3-4 | Morning sun for 2-4 hours, then bright shade.                              |
| Day 5-6 | Longer morning sun plus bright afternoon shade. Keep cells moist.          |
| Day 7   | Ready to plant in early morning or late evening if seedling is not wilted. |

**Do not let tray cells dry out during hardening off. A dry cell can damage the taproot and push dill to bolt early.**

## 12. Transplanting From Trays or Small Pots

Dill is usually best direct-sown, but customers who buy seedlings can still transplant successfully if the root ball is handled carefully.

| Step | Instruction                                                                      |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Water seedlings 1-2 hours before transplanting.                                  |
| 2    | Prepare holes before removing seedlings from the tray/pot.                       |
| 3    | Remove the seedling gently from the bottom of the cell. Do not pull by the stem. |
| 4    | Keep the root ball together. Do not tease, break, or wash the roots.             |
| 5    | Plant at the same soil depth as the tray/pot. Do not bury the crown deeply.      |
| 6    | Press soil gently around the root ball and water immediately.                    |
| 7    | Shade lightly for 1-2 days if weather is hot.                                    |
| 8    | Check morning and evening for the first 3-5 days                                 |

**Best transplant timing: early morning before 8:30 a.m. or late evening after 4:30 p.m. Avoid midday transplanting.**

## 13. Common Pests

| Pest                        | Signs                                                         | Action                                                                            |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Aphids                      | Tiny soft insects on new growth; curling; sticky leaves       | Spray off with water. Use mild soap spray every 3-5 days if needed. Control ants. |
| Caterpillars / parsleyworms | Chewed feathery leaves; droppings; visible worms              | Handpick early morning/evening. Use netting if pressure is high.                  |
| Armyworms                   | Large chewing damage; green/striped worms                     | Inspect regularly and remove. Protect young plantings.                            |
| Leafminers                  | White winding tunnels inside leaves                           | Remove affected leaves. Keep weeds down. Use insect netting for new crops.        |
| Thrips                      | Silvery marks, distorted tips, tiny insects in growing points | Remove damaged tips. Spray lightly if needed. Improve plant health.               |
| Spider mites                | Fine webbing, speckled dry leaves                             | Rinse undersides, avoid drought stress, repeat treatment every 3-5 days.          |



## 14. Common Diseases

| Disease / Problem                    | Signs                                                         | Action                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Damping off                          | Seedling collapses near soil line                             | Avoid overwatering. Improve airflow. Use clean media. Remove collapsed plants. |
| Root rot                             | Wilting with wet soil; yellowing; weak roots                  | Improve drainage. Reduce watering. Repot if container stays soggy.             |
| Powdery mildew                       | White powdery coating on leaves                               | Increase airflow and spacing. Remove bad leaves. Avoid overhead watering late. |
| Downy mildew / leaf blight           | Yellowing patches, gray growth, leaf collapse in damp weather | Keep foliage dry, improve airflow, remove affected leaves.                     |
| Leaf spots                           | Brown/black spots, often worse with wet leaves                | Remove spotted leaves. Water soil, not leaves. Avoid crowding.                 |
| Aster yellows / viral-like disorders | Yellowing, stunting, distorted growth or abnormal flowers     | Remove badly affected plants. Control leafhoppers/aphids and weeds.            |

**Prevention matters more than rescue: clean trays, good drainage, enough space, dry foliage, and early pest control are the best disease protection.**

## 15. ParaLife Trees Support Page

### Need help with your dill plant?

Send clear photos of:

| Photo Needed            | Why                                                         |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Full plant              | Shows size, wilting, spacing, and growth habit.             |
| Leaf close-up           | Shows color, chewing, powder, spotting, or curling.         |
| Leaf underside          | Many pests hide under leaves.                               |
| Stem base and soil/pot  | Shows root rot, damping off, drainage, and moisture issues. |
| Any insect or worm seen | Helps identify the pest and the safest next step.           |

**WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415**

ParaLife Trees - Planting a Life in Paradise

Source basis: Utah State University Extension, University of Minnesota Extension, UC Master Gardeners/UC ANR, RHS, UF/IFAS, and other extension-style herb production references.